



Error Guessing VS Checklist-Based Testing

Experience vs. Structure



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TL;DR

Checklist-Based Testing ensures you don't forget the standard rules (Reliability).

Error Guessing uses your intuition to find weird bugs that aren't written down (Creativity).



The Core Difference

One relies on a **document**, the other relies on **your brain**.

Checklist-Based Testing (The Safety Net)

Focus: Completeness.

You follow a pre-written list of items that *must* be tested for every feature.

- **Goal:** Consistency. Ensure we didn't miss the basics.
- **Example:** "Verify standard fonts," "Check tab order," "Verify error messages."

Error Guessing (The Hunter's Instinct)

Focus: Creativity.

You rely on your experience to guess where the developer might have made a mistake.

- **Goal:** Finding the "Sneaky" bugs.
 - **Example:** "I bet if I click this button double-fast, it will crash." (There is no checklist for this, you just *know*).
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The Pilot vs. The Chef Analogy

Checklist (The Pilot):

Before takeoff, a pilot checks the flaps, fuel, and radio.

They don't guess. They follow the list to ensure safety.

Error Guessing (The Chef):

A chef tastes the soup and thinks, "It needs more salt."

There is no list telling him that. He knows it from years of experience.

The Comparison Matrix

Component: Source

- Checklist: Written standards / Documentation.
- Error Guessing: Tester's intuition and past experience.

Component: Who is it for?

- Checklist: Beginners & Pros (Anyone can follow it).
- Error Guessing: Experienced Testers (Need domain knowledge).

Component: Weakness

- Checklist: Can become "robotic" (Tester stops thinking).
 - Error Guessing: Not reproducible (If you leave, your intuition leaves with you).
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💡 Real World Example: File Upload Feature

The Scenario: A user uploads a profile picture.

📋 Using a Checklist:

- Check max file size (5MB).
- Check allowed formats (.jpg, .png).
- Check success message.

(Result: The feature works as designed).

🕵️ Using Error Guessing:

- "I bet the developer didn't handle a file with **no name**." → Uploads `.jpg`
- "I bet the system crashes if I upload a **0 byte** image." → Uploads empty file
- "What if I upload a file named `DROP TABLE Users`?" → SQL Injection check

(Result: You find 3 bugs that were not on the checklist).

🧠 Why You Need Both

If you **only** use checklists, you will miss the tricky bugs.

If you **only** use error guessing, you will miss the obvious bugs.

A great QA starts with the Checklist to be safe, then switches to Error Guessing to be dangerous.